Europe passes the Ukraine hat

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Presented by Amazon By GERARDO FORTUNA with ZOYA SHEFTALOVICH and MAX GRIERA CIAO THERE. It’s Gerardo Fortuna, back after watching Alejandro González

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CIAO THERE. It’s Gerardo Fortuna, back after watching Alejandro González Iñárritu’s latest movie, “Digger,” on the day the new EU’s Arctic strategy was unveiled, without knowing what it was about. My advice? Read POLITICO’s five takeaways from the strategy first — essential for a full immersive policy experience at the cinema.

In today’s Playbook:

— Should the Socialists challenge Roberta Metsola for the Parliament’s presidency … or let her stay in exchange for concessions?

— EU countries top the global rankings on the rule of law, but cracks are showing as checks on government power weaken across the bloc.

— Faces in the crowd: Kaja Kallas, René Repasi, Steve Witkoff, Claire Boussagol, Valdis Dombrovskis, Marco Rubio, Katarina Barley, Branko Grims, Michael McGrath, Kateřina Konečná, Bjoern Seibert and more …

On today’s Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Katie discuss what Europe’s doing to fight AI deepfakes of your face and voice.

A message from Amazon: Amazon offers additional parental benefits to employees across Europe. A little support at Amazon, when your family starts to grow. Learn more .

DRIVING THE DAY

EU PUSHES ALLIES FOR HELP ON UKRAINE: Brussels wants to use upcoming summits with Canada and the U.K. to squeeze more money for Kyiv out of its partners, according to five EU officials and two EU diplomats Zoya Sheftalovich and I spoke to.

The message? The EU is doing as much as it can. Now it's your turn.

Today's opening move: EU ambassadors are set to discuss the Canada (Oct. 29-30) and U.K. (Nov. 20) summits today, with Ukraine funding expected to form part of the discussions , the two diplomats said.

But the EU "won't be pulling a Trump," the diplomat said, adding the idea is to make the case "without pointing the finger" or explicitly leveraging the closer ties Brussels is currently negotiating with London and Ottawa for more funding. All of the officials and diplomats Playbook spoke to insisted the push isn't a criticism of Canada or the U.K. — more a recognition that as Kyiv's financial gap grows, so should the contributions from allies.

Norway and Japan are also being asked to dig deeper. Tokyo is mainly being approached through the G7 and G20, with Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis leading much of the effort. Both Ottawa and Oslo have already responded positively, according to a Commission official who was granted anonymity, like others cited here, to speak candidly about sensitive diplomatic matters.

"It is now paramount," the Commission official said, pointing to intensifying Russian attacks and an unpredictable Washington. "Now we see every single opportunity [to raise the topic]. I don't see why we would not put it on the table," a second said.

The EU has been asking partners to share the bill for years. But promised billions have been slow to materialize from some countries, and Kyiv's funding gap is getting bigger. Now the money question is finding its way into talks about what countries want from the EU.

The latest EU summit finally put a number on Ukraine's additional funding needs for 2027 — €70 billion. "If the G7 countries put more commitments on the table, then the €70 billion figure can still come down significantly," the second Commission official said.

Plan A before Plan B: Both Commission officials said squeezing more out of international partners is the first step before turning to politically thornier options, including another EU-backed loan or tapping frozen Russian assets.

The latter remains particularly toxic after the spectacular collapse of talks at last December's summit. And Belgium, whose objections helped sink the idea, shows little sign of budging.

MEANWHILE, IN ST. PETERSBURG ⋯ Donald Trump's special envoy Steve Witkoff will offer Vladimir Putin a three-way summit with the U.S. president and Volodymyr Zelenskyy in the latest attempt to secure a ceasefire. Witkoff is heading to Russia after talks in Oslo yesterday at which the EU was represented by Ursula von der Leyen's powerful chief of staff Bjoern Seibert.

A new twist in the Starlink saga: After top diplomats traded barbs over support for Ukraine yesterday — with Kaja Kallas accusing the U.S. of pushing Kyiv toward surrender and Marco Rubio insisting Washington hasn't deliberately withheld assistance — Zelenskyy said Kyiv is once again receiving early warnings about Russian strikes. The Wall Street Journal then dropped a story late last night claiming American officials are blaming Elon Musk for the satellite slowdown that blindsided Ukraine last week.

Maybe it's personal? Some European officials and diplomats think Trump's stance on Ukraine is as much a product of personal preference as any political aim . "Trump doesn't like Zelenskyy," one government official told my colleagues Tim Ross and Veronika Melkozerova. "He just doesn't like him."

BIG AND BREAKING

TARIFF THREAT: Beijing says it'll retaliate if the U.K. raises tariffs on Chinese electric vehicles to align with the European Union, Caroline Hug reports.

WHAT RIOTS? France's first presidential poll since the weekend's mass unrest suggests the race has barely budged despite the political finger-pointing — Marine Le Pen remains out front, with Jean-Luc Mélenchon in a close race for second.

FEAR FACTOR: Republicans facing an uphill battle in next month's midterms have seized on the violence in France , telling American voters they'll face similar chaos if the Democrats regain power.

CLIMATE TARGETS: Center-right lawmakers are taking aim at the EU's rules on methane emissions and a new carbon price on driving and heating, Ben Munster and Ben Makuch report.

THE SOCIALISTS' DILEMMA

THE PRESIDENCY QUESTION: The Socialists and Democrats and their newly reelected leader, Iratxe García, have a big question to answer, Max Griera reports. Should they challenge the European People's Party's Roberta Metsola for the European Parliament presidency — which they say is theirs under a power-sharing deal — or back the incumbent in exchange for a pledge from the EPP to stop working with the far right?

Germany's Katarina Barley, the S&D's agreed candidate in 2024, hasn't pushed publicly for the presidency and her silence has fueled debate over whether to give up a bid for the position in return for concessions, according to five S&D lawmakers. Barley didn't respond to Playbook's request for comment.

Some MEPs think challenging Metsola would be futile and the group should push for a deal instead. "Why should we kamikaze for no reason?" said one MEP, granted anonymity to discuss internal strategy. Another lawmaker said Metsola is "very firmly established" and the S&D should focus on keeping the current distribution of posts and securing political commitments. A third said maintaining the status quo could count as a victory, though reassurance on isolating the far right is crucial.

But what does the leadership think? The S&D will first ask for a public political agreement, "because policies come first," García said after her reelection, hinting she wants that coalition pact in place before discussing the presidency with the EPP. There is an existing written agreement that commits the EPP to alternate the presidency with a center-left candidate, an S&D official said, meaning the group "will need to decide how to proceed."

A possible trade: Barley could get the Parliament's first vice presidency, according to a person familiar with the discussions. If the S&D drops its claim this time round, German lawmakers could seek the S&D leadership in 2029, with delegation chief René Repasi increasingly mentioned as a contender, according to one official and three lawmakers.

His influence is growing: Repasi has led smaller delegations' push for more posts, proposing reforms to address what they see as larger delegations' dominance, four MEPs said. He declined to comment.

ELSEWHERE IN PARLIAMENT ⋯ Czech communist MEP Kateřina Konečná, a former member of The Left, joined the Patriots for Europe on Tuesday, lifting the group to 85 MEPs and surpassing the European Conservatives and Reformists to become the third-biggest group in the Parliament.

Konečná told Max that the Patriots have the "greatest overlap" with Stačilo!, the left-wing Czech coalition for which she was the lead candidate in 2024. The ECR could catch up to the Patriots if Slovenian former EPP lawmaker Branko Grims joins its ranks.

And in the EPP: Czechia's Danuše Nerudová and Portugal's Sebastião Bugalho missed out as the group reelected its 10 vice chairs. Manfred Weber was reelected chair with 164 votes in favor, 11 against and 8 abstentions — slightly more opposition than in 2024, when he secured 161 votes in favor, 8 against and 2 abstentions.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

Ambassadors will today discuss a delay to the EU's methane regulation, but what is that and why delay it? The EU Methane Regulation entered into force in 2024, establishing requirements to measure, monitor, report, verify and reduce emissions of the potent greenhouse gas in the energy sector. But industry and some EU member countries say the infrastructure needed to meet a January 2027 deadline requiring fossil fuel importers to track methane emissions isn't in place, and they want a delay. The Commission partly blames the delayed implementation on member countries.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked you whether you've ever been targeted by a deepfake. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shout-out.

DEFENDERS OF DEMOCRACY?

IS THE RULE OF LAW SLIPPING? EU countries are doing well when it comes to upholding democratic and judicial safeguards, but some aren't doing quite as well as in years past. That's according to the World Justice Project's latest Rule of Law Index , published today and seen by Hanne Cokelaere.

At first glance ⋯ the EU's record looks great. The index puts Denmark, Finland, Sweden, Luxembourg and Germany at the very top of the global ranking and says that Poland — now at number 32 — has made major strides since 2023. (Outside the EU, Norway also ranks highly.)

But but but: Some countries have seen slight drops in their ratings. France, the Czech Republic, Romania and Bulgaria are among the countries that recorded losses since last year and several countries are on a longer-term downward trajectory. Across the EU, weaker checks on government powers were a common reason for declines. The U.K. has also slipped.

Chin up, Budapest: For now, Hungary is at the bottom of the European ranking. No need to tell PM Péter Magyar, who came into power in May with promises to restore democratic and judicial independence.

Way to go: "Europe has some of the strongest rule of law standards in the world ⋯ But strong does not mean there is no room for improvement," Rule of Law Commissioner Michael McGrath told Playbook, adding it's why the Commission monitors countries and suggests changes. "Checks on power,

independent courts, a strong fight against corruption and a free civil society are not obstacles to governing. They are what give citizens confidence in those who govern them."

Michel Barnier, Borys Budka and Raúl Suárez on stage in Brussels, and you in the conversation. Join the European Pulse Seminar, take part in the live crowdstorming and help decide which questions Europeans will be asked in the 2027 European Pulse Poll. Apply to join onsite , seats are limited.

4 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

DEEPFAKE DEMAND: The S&D wants an EU-wide ban on harmful, non-consensual or deceptive deepfakes — and for tech platforms to stop them spreading, rather than waiting for victims to complain.

ABORTION VOTE: Poland's parliament last night approved two bills backed by Donald Tusk's government that would loosen the country's strict abortion restrictions — but they could now be vetoed by conservative President Karol Nawrocki.

MARITIME STORM: Brussels has slammed the eastern Libyan parliament's ratification of a maritime deal with Turkey, Nektaria Stamouli reports, calling it "null and void" and a violation of international law. Ursula von der Leyen and António Costa backed Greece and Cyprus, which strongly oppose the deal, in a joint statement .

CASE CLOSED: A judge in Milan has closed the last Italian strand of the Qatargate affair due to insufficient evidence of money laundering involving consultancy firm Equality. Le Soir wrote it up .

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Light rain and a moderate breeze. High of 14C.

PLAYING PLAYBOOK: Spotted a mysterious new POLITICO handle on social media? Don't panic. Students at ULB are staging a European Parliament simulation, complete with someone playing our very own Max Griera.

MOVING ON: Axis Advisors Partner Claire Boussagol is stepping down at the end of October to pursue other opportunities, she announced in a post on LinkedIn . Simon Wilson, a former BBC Brussels and Washington bureau chief, will become a partner at Axis on Nov. 1, to lead policy communications.

GUAC AND ROLL: Brussels isn't exactly renowned for its Mexican food scene — which got Playbook's Sebastian Starcevic wondering where one goes to find the best nachos, tacos and spicy margs in town.

Adios: Gringo, a popular taco spot in Châtelain, appears to have closed its doors (we didn't love that their margaritas came in a can). But PIÑA Taqueria in Saint-Gilles is still slinging a mean marg, with a gluten-free taco menu and tasty grilled Padrón peppers to boot.

Yes, we know they're technically Tex-Mex: At Rosita's Cantina in the city center, the fajitas arrived sizzling and steaming, just as they should. The spicy mango margarita was a delight, too. Less impressive: somewhat stale tortillas and nachos that could have done with a little more cheese.

The other contenders: Los Charros does decent tostadas and tamales. Tip: If you order a beer, splash out an extra €2.50 for a michelada. CHEZWaWa is your go-to for a burrito fix, while El Quetzal boasts an impressive selection of mezcal and tequila alongside beautiful indigenous art. All three joints are in

the city center. What did we miss?

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: The AfD is playing down the online dump of hundreds of thousands of hacked emails and internal documents — but it could be days, if not weeks, before we know how politically explosive the leaked material is.

Paris: Presidential hopefuls are feeling out alliances , with Raphaël Glucksmann and ex-PM Bernard Cazeneuve reportedly meeting for breakfast and conservatives Bruno Retailleau and David Lisnard doing lunch.

Madrid: Pedro Sánchez and far-right leader Santiago Abascal are both campaigning early in smaller provinces , where a surge for Vox could shift the balance between the larger parties.

London: Andy Burnham's government is poised to approve drilling in a North Sea gas field — a move that'll stoke anger among environmentalists.

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AGENDA

— Coreper II meets at 9 a.m., and Coreper I at 9:30 a.m.

— European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen and European Council President António Costa participate in the European Parliament plenary debate in Strasbourg, from 9 a.m., to discuss the conclusions of the Oct. 15-16 European Council meeting, with Costa reporting on the summit's outcome.

— Alternative for Germany leader Alice Weidel presents "A New Deal for Europe" at a press conference at the European Parliament at 4:30 p.m., hosted by MEPs René Aust and Alexander Sell.

— Rule of Law Commissioner Michael McGrath speaks at the European Parliament's Plenary Session on the rule of law in Malta, at 3 p.m. Follow live .

— EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas meets Vietnamese Defense Minister General Phan Văn Giang and Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan.

— Presentation of the Daphne Caruana Galizia Prize for Journalism in the European Parliament, opened by Parliament President Roberta Metsola, at 6 p.m. Watch live .

— Gates Foundation Chair Bill Gates meets Commission Executive Vice President Henna Virkkunen, Agriculture Commissioner Christophe Hansen and Startups Commissioner Ekaterina Zaharieva. Zaharieva participates in a Gates Foundation roundtable on "AI, Equity and Europe's Choice."

— Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius meets Czech Prime Minister Andrej Babiš and President Petr Pavel in Prague.

— Berlin Global Dialogue in Berlin, with speakers including German Chancellor Friedrich Merz. Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis will take part in a session on delivering a more competitive Europe at 3:15 p.m. Full program .

— Enlargement Commissioner Marta Kos meets Montenegrin Prime Minister Milojko Spajić, Montenegrin President Jakov Milatović and Kosovo's Prime Minister Albin Kurti, in Montenegro.

— Environment Commissioner Jessika Roswall delivers a keynote address at the Global Bioeconomy Summit 2026 in Dublin.

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Rosa Estaràs Ferragut; former MEP Matthias Groote; Mastercard's Katie LaZelle; European Commission's Tobias Müllensiefen and Annemarie Huber; Israel's PM Benjamin Netanyahu.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere, Gregorio Sorgi Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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